

Apple PowerBook G4

With the PowerBook G4, Apple seems to have put a lot of effort into getting things just right. They have here come up with the successor to the Titanium PowerBook, again implementing a G4 processor, but the 1.5 GHz has been pumped up to 1.67 GHz, and the titanium has been replaced by aluminium—and that's why it's been nicked the AlBook.

The AlBook comes in three flavours—the 12-inch, the 17-inch, and the one we had a look at—the 15-inch.

All new PowerBooks come with a standard 512 MB of memory, fast graphics, integrated Airport 802.11g, Bluetooth 2.0 wireless networking, and two new Apple technologies—the scrolling TrackPad and the Sudden Motion Sensor (SMS).

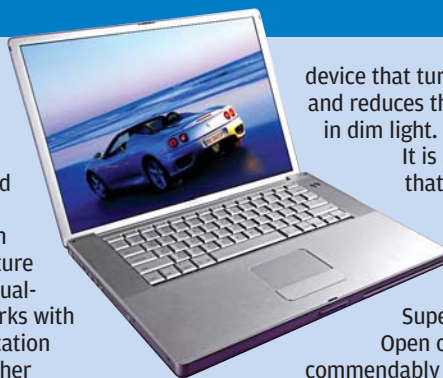
The SMS senses change in axis position and accelerated movement. In the event of a drop or fall, the SMS instantly parks the hard drive heads so they won't scratch the disks on impact, lessening the risk of damage and improving your chances of retrieving valuable data. When the SMS senses the PowerBook is once again been

levelled, it automatically unlocks hard drive heads.

The TrackPad can sense dual-touch and switch to the scroll feature instantly upon dual-touch, and it works with almost all application windows. The other interesting aspect about this Apple is the OS: Tiger, the latest Mac OS, looks very stable, and is laden with such features as the 'DashBoard', and most importantly, the 'Spotlight'—a real-time indexing engine finds anything on your hard disk as-you-type!

Graphics on the AlBook 15-inch is powered by the ATi Radeon 9700 64 MB (AGP) GPU. The LCD screen is 15.2 inches diagonally, and the picture is clear. The hard disk is 80 GB, and the processor is a 1.67 GHz PowerPC G4.

Also notable is the ambient light-sensor



device that turns on the backlit keyboard and reduces the intensity of the LCD screen in dim light.

It is also the only laptop out there that has both FireWire 400 and 800. The other ports are Gigabit Ethernet, S-Video out and DVI. This one also flaunts a slot-loadable SuperDrive (DVD-R/CD-RW).

Open or closed, the chassis is commendably rigid for such a thin structure. The AlBook has all its ports on the sides rather than on the back.

There are also no easy-to-break doors hiding the ports!

There's one issue, though: battery life. We tested it by playing a DVD video, and the time recorded was a little less than two hours. Note that this is the worst-case scenario; under normal operation, you can add a 40 to 60 minutes to that.

More than just a pleasant change in a Windows world, this is a unique experience: a world of innovation and perfection at a reasonable price—Rs 1,37,500.

inside. It even came bundled with a Bluetooth mouse that also had the Ferrari logo!

For its designer looks, good build quality, specifications and features, and the Ferrari insignia associated with it, we gave the Acer Ferrari 4002 the highest flaunt rating of 8.19.

Next was the IBM ThinkPad T43 which, with its rough-and-tough looks and a slightly boxy design, seemed more like a business laptop. IBM has incorporated innovative features into its laptops, such as motion sensors that park the hard drive head when they detect that the laptop is falling. Then there were some other important features such as fingerprint recognition and the dual pointer option.

Thanks to its rugged build quality, good design and the brand name, the IBM T43 came in second in the flaunt value department with a score of 7.61. The Fujitsu laptop, had a nice finish, and had some useful features such as fingerprint recognition. It was comfortable to work on, and its 15.4-inch widescreen LCD display was above average. Though it was the heaviest of the lot, we rated it third.

Fourth up was the Samsung Note PC X20, which, too, had the standalone DVD/Audio CD player feature. It had some cool features such as Samsung's DNIE and DNSe for image and sound enhancement. The ATi Radeon 9600 card is good for graphics-intensive applications.

Conclusion

Priced at Rs 1,15,000, the Fujitsu LifeBook LBN3510's pricing almost worked against it. But it still managed to grab the *Digit* 'Best Buy Silver' award, due to its good performance, features and impressive package contents.

The *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' winner here was the Acer Ferrari 4002, with its designer looks, good overall features, performance and specifications, as well as a great flaunt value.

A Final Word

In this comparison test, we've seen some laptops that can be considered niche. The Acer Ferrari looks simply great, and the Ferrari logo creates an aura of sorts around this laptop.

Similarly, the Sony VAIO, too, had looks and features that could blow anyone away. The 'VAIO' name itself has a certain magic to it.

The Apple PowerBook G4 was in a league of its own. It is the ultimate in style, and is a laptop with an attitude. If you are searching for a laptop to brag about without a platform in mind, your search ends here. This is the laptop for you—period!

If you're out to make a point and re-affirm to the world that you're no mere mortal, go get one of these! ☒

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